

# Warrior Toughness

## TOPIC LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Upon successful completion of this topic, the student will be able to:

1. Understand the attributes of the Navy's Warrior Toughness (WT) model.
2. Recognize the connection of WT to the Navy Leadership Development Framework.
3. Recognize the components of the Warrior Mindset (mind, body, spirit).
4. Recognize techniques for sustaining peak performance under varying degrees of stress.

## STUDENT PREPARATION

Student Support Material

1. Mindfulness and Resilience videos
2. Warrior Toughness overview document

Primary References

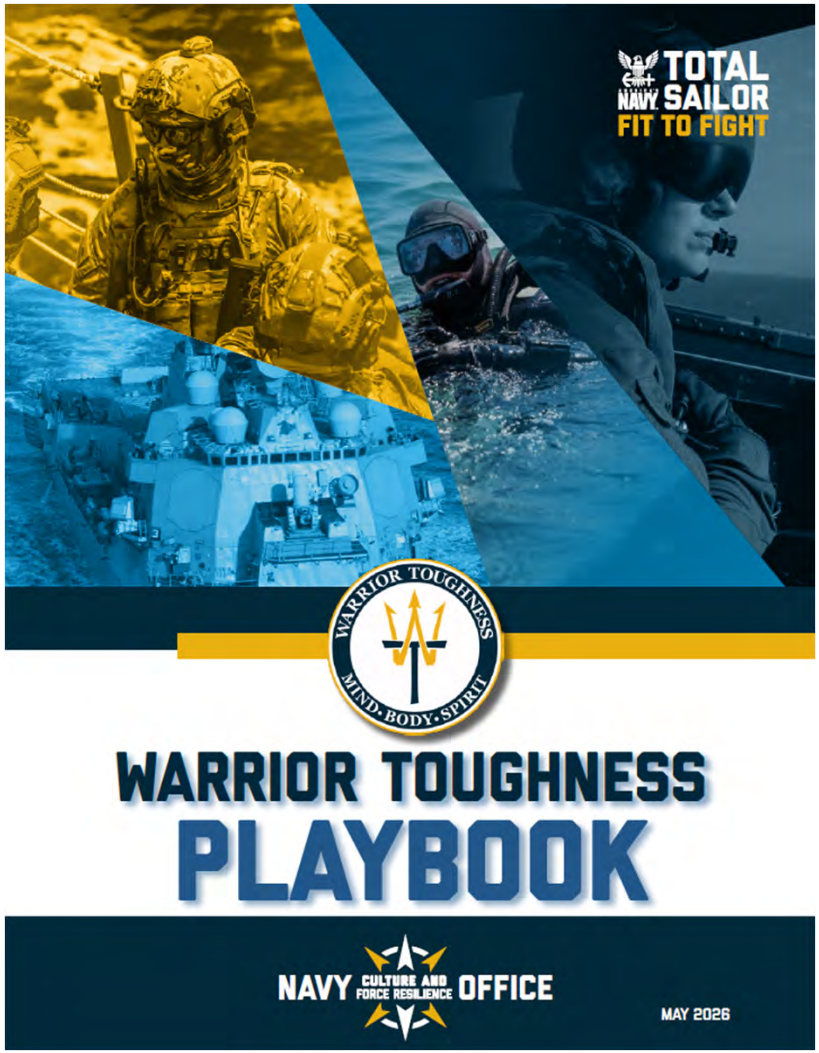
1. Warrior Toughness Overview. https://www.netc.navy.mil/Warrior-Toughness/
2. NAVADMIN 205/21, SUBJ: Aligning Toughness, Resilience, and Mental Health Support

Additional References

1. Culture of Excellence https://www.mynavyhr.navy.mil/Support-Services/Culture-Resilience/Culture-of-Excellence/
2. Warrior Toughness Playbook https://www.mynavyhr.navy.mil/Portals/55/Support/Culture%20Resilience/WarriorToughness/WT%20Playbook_2026_v1.26_508.pdf?ver=njWm0BQrmgDSdixERre8RQ%3d%3d
3. Warrior Toughness Suite of Products https://www.mynavyhr.navy.mil/Support-Services/Culture-Resilience/Warrior-Toughness/Suite-of-Products/

# Agenda

- What is Warrior Toughness?
- Developing a “Warrior Mindset”
- Warrior Toughness Skills
- Application as an EDO



# What is Warrior Toughness?

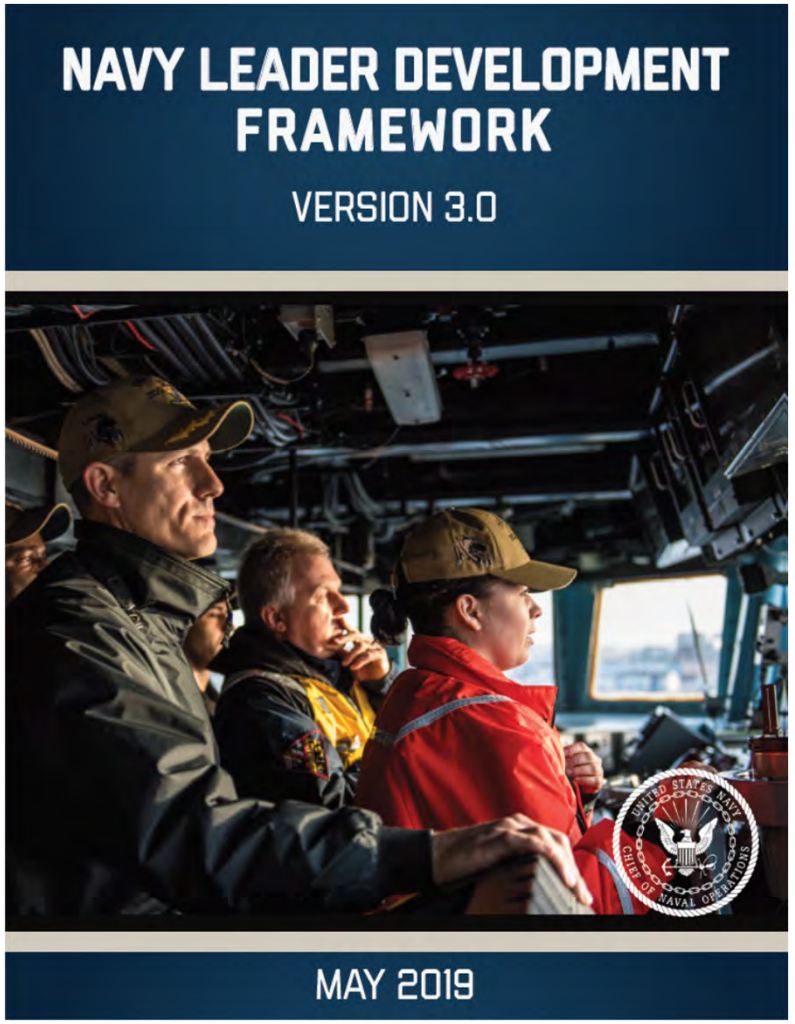



- ***Warrior Toughness is a set of skills that enables Sailors to take a hit and keep fighting, perform under pressure, and excel in life's daily challenges***
- These skills, grounded in the science of human performance optimization, train the Mind, Body, and Spirit to perform at our best every time
- These are not new ideas; they are winning habits used by high performers in every field—from elite athletes to special operations forces

# Navy Leadership Development Framework

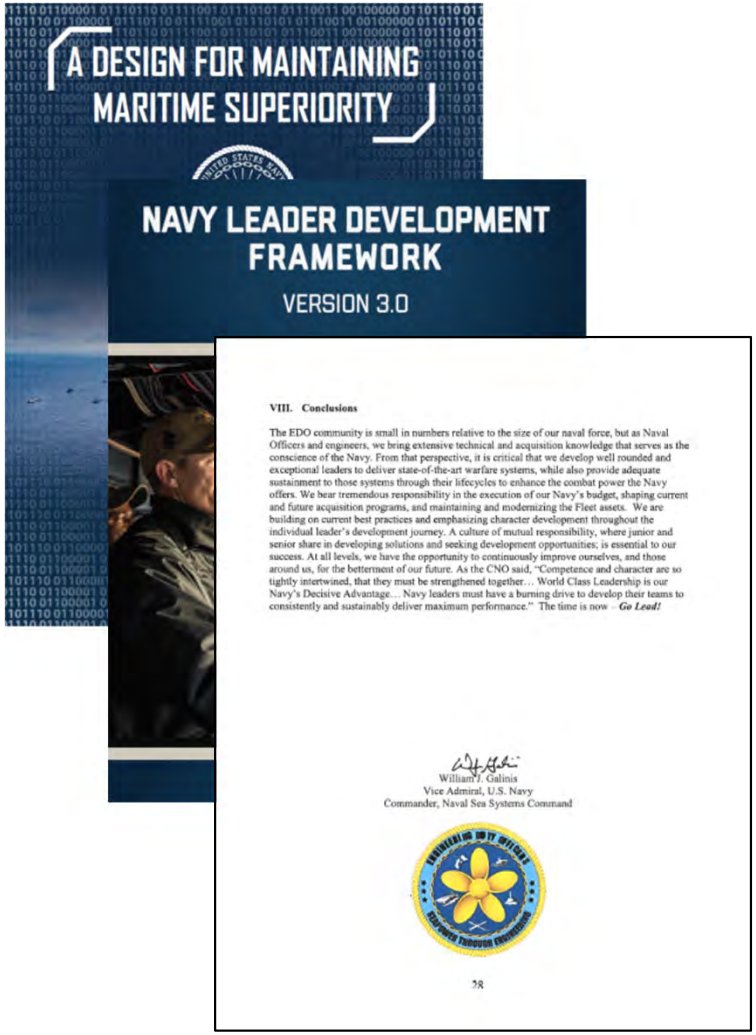
- Core Values
  - Honor
  - Courage
  - Commitment

- Core Attributes
  - Toughness
  - Integrity
  - Initiative
  - Accountability



# Toughness & Resilience

- From Design 2.0:
  - One of the four core attributes: Integrity, Accountability, Initiative, and ***Toughness***
  - Toughness defined: We can take a hit and keep going, tapping all sources of strength and ***resilience***… We don't give up the ship, we never give up on our shipmates, and we never give up on ourselves. We are never out of the fight
- From NLDF 3.0:
  - Effective Navy leaders demonstrate a deliberate commitment to grow personally and professionally throughout their careers…They pursue excellence in accordance with our core attributes of integrity, accountability, initiative, and ***toughness***
- From ED LDF 3.0:
  - ***Resilience***: Deals effectively with pressure; remains optimistic and persistent, even under adversity. Recovers quickly from setbacks



# Why does this matter?

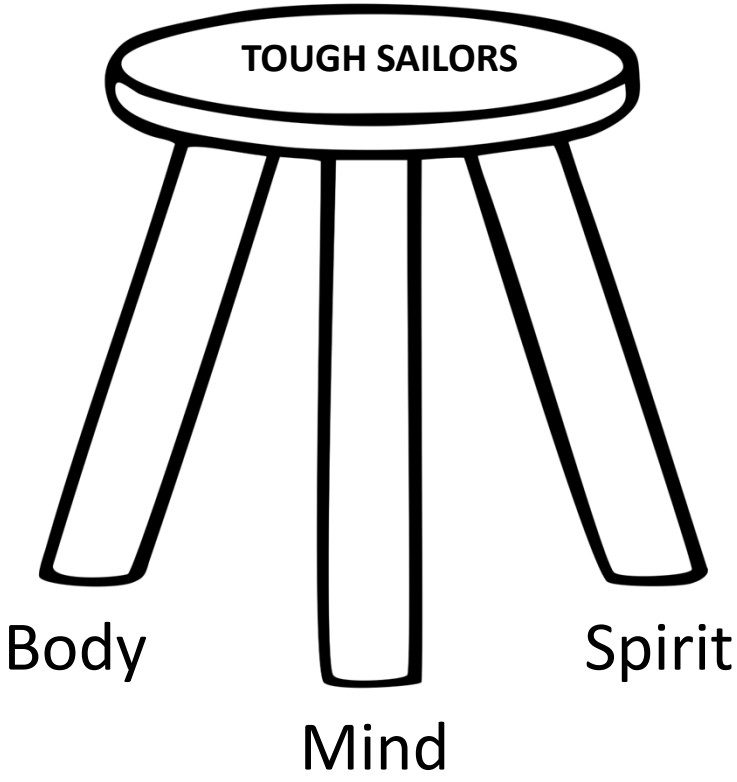
- USS CARNEY
  - 51 engagements
  - 20 targets destroyed in defensive strikes
  - Successfully engaged Iranian ballistic missiles fired at Israel








# How is Toughness Trained?







*Train the **whole** person*

# Warrior Mindset






THINK OF THE WARRIOR MINDSET AS

**PBED FOR THE BRAIN**

- Plan = Commitment
- Brief = Preparation
- Execute = Execution
- Debrief = Reflection

We use PBED to improve every evolution. We use the Warrior Mindset to improve **our performance** in those evolutions.

# Developing a "Warrior Mindset"

- Commitment
  - Builds on our ***Core Values*** by empowering Sailors to persevere through hardship and overcome challenges. Committed Sailors possess a sense of purpose and personal philosophy that enables them to overcome adversity and build resilience as they strive to live out their personal values
- Preparation
  - Strengthens our minds, bodies, and spirits to better withstand destructive stress, while embracing and leveraging the stress that builds us into a stronger warfighting team
- Execution
  - Where our commitment and preparation are ultimately tested. That test may come from complex combat evolutions or from the life challenges we face day-to-day
- Reflection
  - How we actively learn from those tests. It includes both group reflection such as after-action reviews that reinforce what we learned as a team, but also individual reflection where we ask ourselves what we did well and acknowledge where we could do better

# Warrior Toughness Skills

- Warrior Ethos
- Mindfulness
- Energy Management
- Healthy Behaviors
- Goal Setting
- Intentional Recovery
- Performance Statements
- Mental Rehearsal
- Flexible Thinking
- Recalibration
- Peer-to-peer Support
- Sea Stories

- Emotional Intelligence (EQ)
- Combat and Operational Stress First Aid (COSFA)
- Core Leader Functions



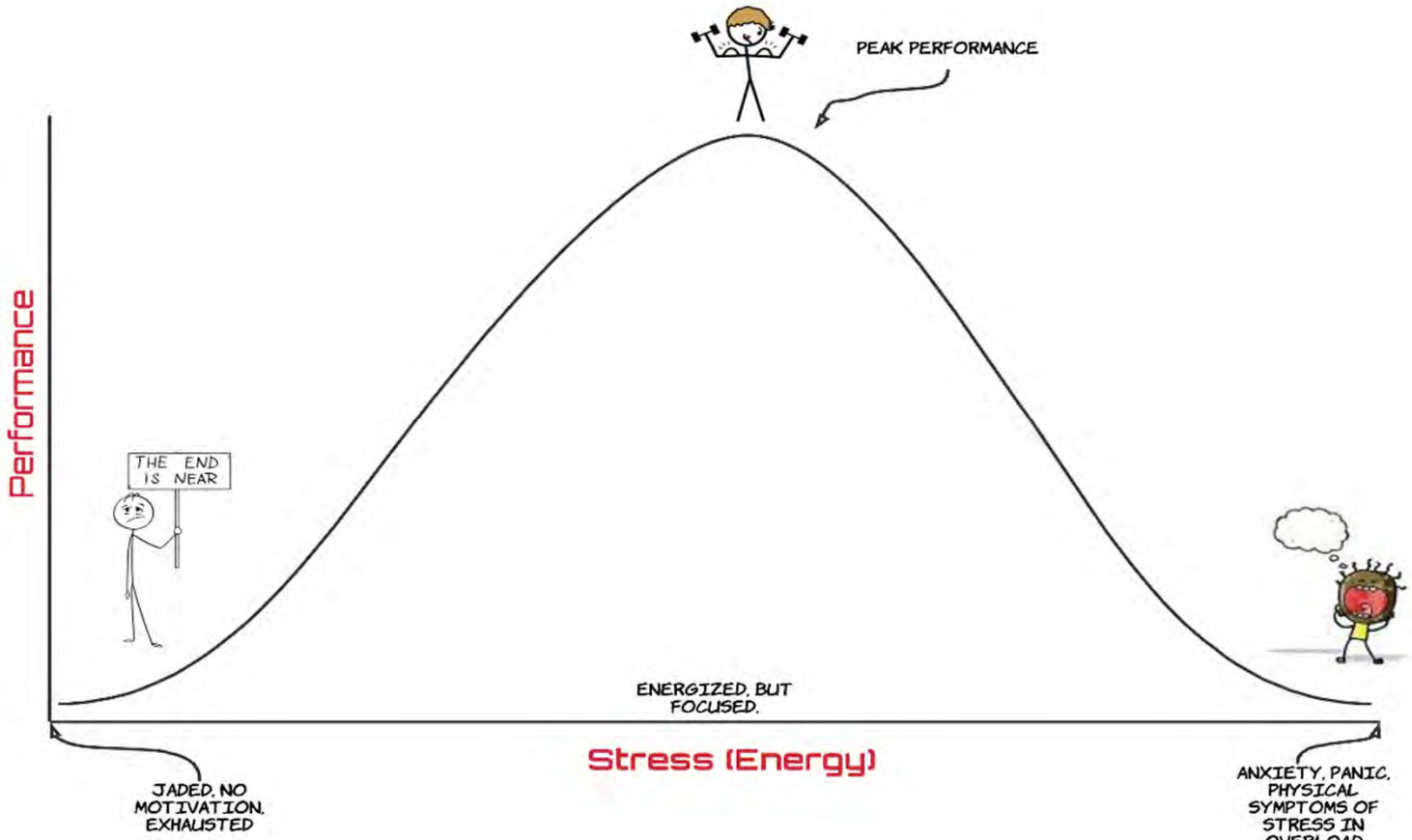
# Warrior Ethos

- Your Warrior Ethos is the foundation of the Warrior Mindset
- It fuels commitment and provides direction when things get hard
- Knowing your “why” keeps you grounded
- A Warrior Ethos doesn’t have to be perfect; it just has to be yours. Keep it short, honest, and actionable. Review it during milestones. Share it at midterm counseling. Let it grow with you



# Understanding Stress

- Success requires ***stress***
  - There is an optimal level
  - Different activities require different levels of energy/stress



# Mindfulness

- Mindfulness is the ability to stay fully present in the moment; aware of what you're doing, how you're feeling, and what's happening around you, without judgment or distraction
- It's not about being calm all the time, it's about being aware and in control when it counts



| THREE PRACTICAL WAYS TO EXERCISE MINDFULNESS | | |
|---|---|---|
| **BODY SCAN** | **MENTAL SCAN** | **PROGRESSIVE MUSCLE RELAXATION (PMR)** |
| Start at the top of your head and mentally scan down to your feet. Focus on physical sensations; tightness, warmth and movement. When your attention drifts, gently bring it back.<br>This helps build focus and self-awareness. | Sit quietly and observe your thoughts without judgment. Acknowledge them, then let them go like waves passing on the surface.<br>This is especially helpful before bed, during recovery, or when your mind feels overloaded. | Tense and release muscle groups, one at a time from your hands to your shoulders to your legs.<br>This is especially useful before evolutions requiring precision, like weapons handling or fine repairs. |

# Energy Management



- This is not about “always being hyped” or “always staying calm.” It’s about knowing how to get in the zone
- That means learning to recognize your current state, read the environment, and up-regulate or down-regulate, like using a thermostat to adjust the temperature, as needed

**Energy Management techniques include:**

**MENTAL TOOLS**
such as Self-Talk, Performance Statements, Mental Rehearsal, Recalibration, and Flexible Thinking. These help regulate energy by focusing attention, controlling breathing, and guiding action.

**EXTERNAL CUES**
like music, sound, or imagery. Energizing inputs (e.g., upbeat music or motivational videos) can help up-regulate; calming inputs (e.g., slow rhythms or nature sounds) can help down-regulate.

**PHYSICAL MOVEMENT**
even brief, can reset energy levels. Standing up after sitting too long, walking before a stressful event, or doing a few pushups before a brief; motion helps align your body to match the task at hand.

# Recalibration

- There are times when the task or the situation does not allow you to take time to do Intentional Recovery or a deliberate Energy Management technique, but you still need to focus and work through stressful situations and evolutions

**Recalibration is simply regulating your breathing. To conduct effective Recalibration, follow this breathing pattern:**

- Inhale for five seconds
- Exhale for seven seconds
- Repeat 3-5 times to realize benefits



- ***Recalibration is NOT a break, a pause, or a time out***

# Intentional Recovery

- Mind: If the day was filled with monotonous tasks, consider reading or listening to a podcast that challenges your thinking
- Body: Go to bed early to rest and recover. If the day lacked movement, like one spent behind a desk, use a workout to re-engage physically and restore balance
- Spirit: After a tough day or a personal setback, like failure to promote, recharge by reading spiritual material, talking with someone who encourages and supports you, or by listening to a motivational podcast

| INTENTIONAL RECOVERY OPPORTUNITIES INCLUDE: | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **WORK DAY** | **POST-DUTY** | **LIBERTY** | **LEAVE** |
| Brief activities (30 seconds to 5 minutes) built into the daily routine. | Targeted to specific recovery needs after the workday to enable optimal performance the following day such as an intentional transition from work to home. | Activities performed to facilitate balance and engagement with one's values.<br>May require a greater allotment of time. | Activities that further increase recovery and reestablish a sense of self and one's connections. |
| **Examples:**<br>▸ Tactical breathing<br>▸ Quick walk<br>▸ Stretching<br>▸ Short mental rest | **Examples:**<br>▸ Music on commute<br>▸ Journaling after watch<br>▸ Light conversation | **Examples:**<br>▸ Work out<br>▸ Structured downtime<br>▸ Time with family or friends | **Examples:**<br>▸ Spiritual retreats<br>▸ Outdoor trips<br>▸ Home visits |

# Healthy Behaviors

- Mind: Develop skills that improve how you think and respond, such as problem-solving, journaling, mindfulness, and reading books and articles
- Body: Prioritize sleep, movement, nutrition, and preventative medical care
- Spirit: Connect to something greater than yourself through your faith, values, family, or service

| SLEEP | |
|---|---|
| STRATEGIES FOR SUCCESS | BARRIERS TO SUCCESS |
| ✓ Stick to a sleep schedule and bedtime routine | ! Screen time within 60 minutes of sleep |
| ✓ Relax, meditate, read a book, or stretch | ! Use of caffeine, nicotine, and alcohol |
| ✓ Use headphones, ear plugs, or eye masks | ! Using sleeping pills (unless prescribed) |

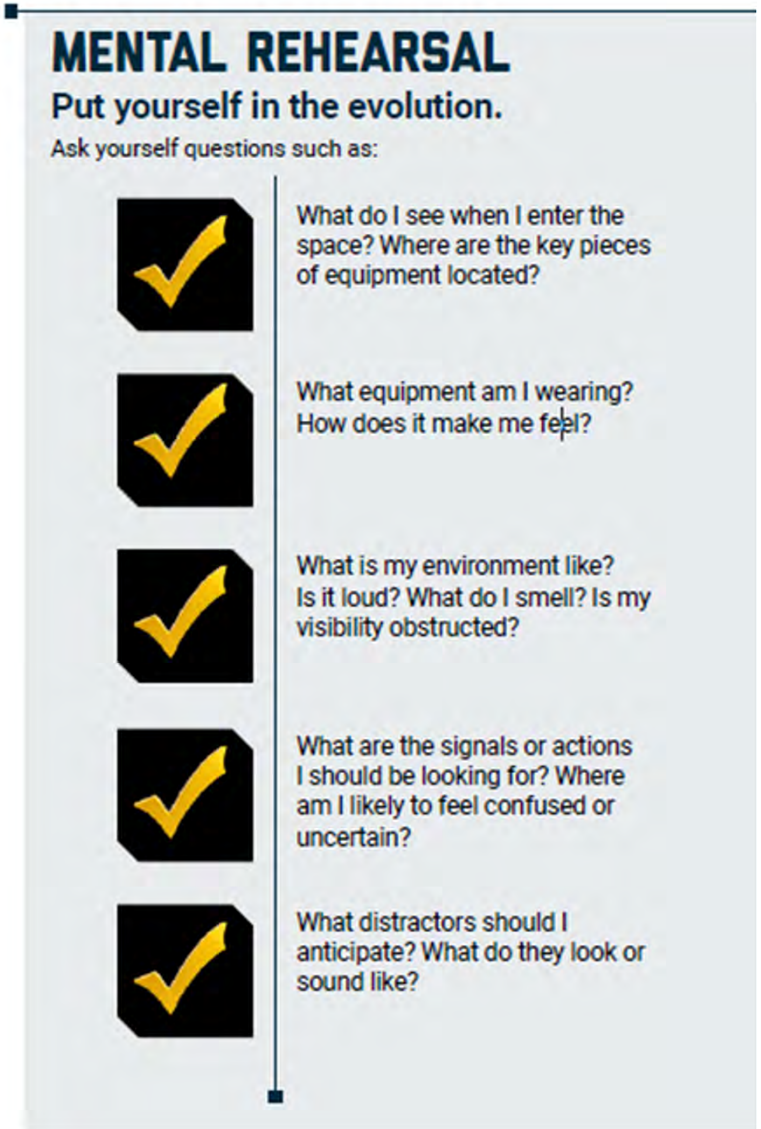
| DIET | |
|---|---|
| STRATEGIES FOR SUCCESS | BARRIERS TO SUCCESS |
| ✓ Eat mindfully, read the food label | ! Strict diets |
| ✓ Make careful meal selections when eating out | ! Diet fads/trends |
| ✓ Only eat when you are hungry | ! Starvation or excessive fasting routines |

| PHYSICAL FITNESS | |
|---|---|
| STRATEGIES FOR SUCCESS | BARRIERS TO SUCCESS |
| ✓ Exercise regularly year-round, not just during PFA cycles | ! Being too hard on yourself |
| ✓ Exercise with a friend, family member, or shipmate | ! Being impatient with results, setting unrealistic expectations |
| ✓ Establish a well-rounded fitness program | ! Interruptions to schedule |

| SPIRITUAL READINESS | |
|---|---|
| STRATEGIES FOR SUCCESS | BARRIERS TO SUCCESS |
| ✓ Write, revisit, and reflect on your Warrior Ethos | ! Drifting from Core Values under pressure |
| ✓ Connect regularly with a faith community or trusted individual for support and perspective | ! Isolation or lack of intentional relationships |
| ✓ Talk to a Chaplain, mentor, or peer when struggling with doubt, grief, or fatigue | ! Believing spiritual support is only for religious or crisis moments |

# Mental Rehearsal

- Mental Rehearsals should be in a deliberate, step-by-step order, in accordance with a checklist or Standard Operating Procedures for the evolution
- Concentrate on the most challenging actions that you know you must execute well
- The more vivid, detailed, and holistic a Mental Rehearsal is, the more realistic and effective it will be

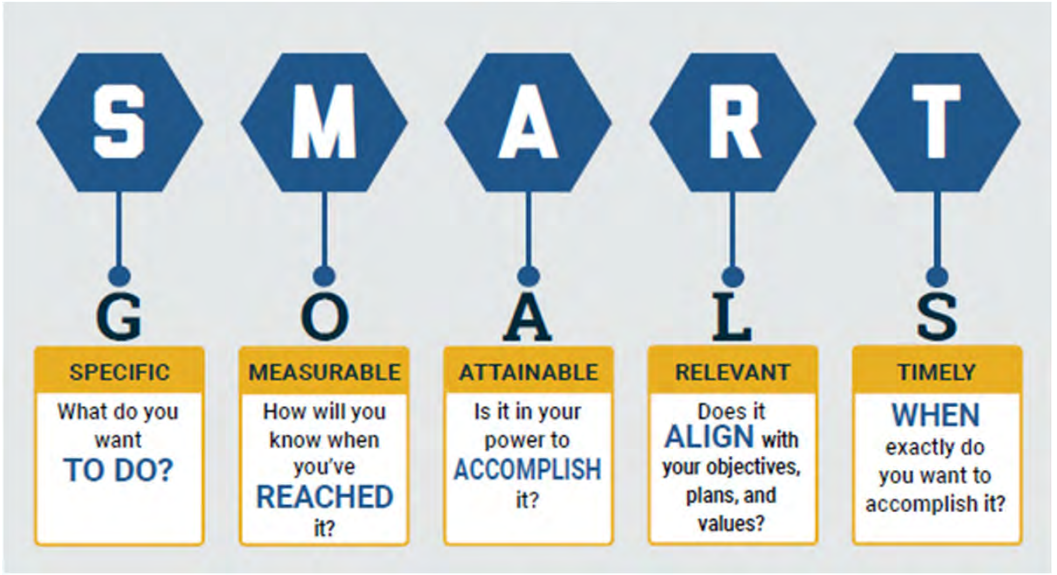


# Goal Setting

- Outcome Goals are aspirational, often overarching and may have subordinate process and performance goals, and often the hardest to measure up to
- Performance Goals have defined targets that will help an individual know if they are progressing towards achieving their Outcome Goals. An effective Performance Goal often uses Specific, Measurable, Attainable, Relevant, and Timely ( S.M.A.R.T. ) criteria
- Process Goals are the easiest to do and are the small “next steps” to measure movement towards completion of the Performance Goals



MWR Deadlift Party: dvidshub.net



# Performance Statements

- ***Performance Statements*** are short, powerful phrases that help you stay focused and in control during high-stress situations. These statements give you a way to interrupt unhelpful self-talk and re-center on what matters

Build a few that fit your role and routine

Test them under pressure

Say them out loud

The more you use them, the more automatic they become



# Flexible Thinking

- Flexible Thinking is the ability to think about new or different ways to approach a situation, allowing Sailors to manage stress and optimize performance while adapting to and overcoming adversity



## Apply Flexible Thinking In Your Daily Life

**Challenge assumptions** – Instead of taking things at face value, ask yourself, What if the opposite were true? Is there another way to see this?

**Shift perspectives** – Put yourself in someone else's shoes, even when you strongly disagree with them. Understanding different viewpoints makes you a more versatile thinker.

**Embrace uncertainty** – Try stepping outside your comfort zone. Engage in activities that push you to think in new ways, like learning a new skill or debating a topic from multiple sides.

**Play with possibilities** – Brainstorm multiple solutions to a problem without judging them right away. Sometimes the most unexpected ideas turn out to be the best ideas.

# Emotional Intelligence (EQ)

- Emotional Intelligence, or EQ, is your ability to understand and manage your own emotions, while also recognizing and responding to the emotions of others. It's what helps you stay composed under pressure, lead with trust, and keep your team aligned when tensions rise. In high-stakes environments, EQ elevates reason over reaction and allows you to act with clarity and purpose

| BEST PRACTICES FOR BUILDING YOUR EMOTIONAL INTELLIGENCE: | | | | |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **SELF-AWARENESS** | **SELF-REGULATION** | **MOTIVATION** | **EMPATHY** | **SOCIAL SKILLS** |
| ▸ Recognize your emotions<br>▸ Keep a journal<br>▸ Slow down<br>▸ Practice mindfulness<br>▸ Re-examine your Warrior Ethos | ▸ Know your values<br>▸ Hold yourself accountable<br>▸ Practice being calm<br>▸ Flexible Thinking<br>▸ Practice gratitude | ▸ Sacrificial service<br>▸ Be hopeful and confident in your efforts<br>▸ Practice optimism | ▸ Put yourself in someone else's position<br>▸ Pay attention to body language<br>▸ Acknowledge the feelings of others | ▸ Learn conflict resolution<br>▸ Improve your communication skills<br>▸ Learn to praise others |



# Combat and Operational Stress First Aid (COSFA)

- Combat and Operational Stress First Aid (COSFA) is a simple, flexible process used to recognize stress reactions early and offer immediate support. Learning the COSFA model helps Sailors protect their teammates' health, restore performance under pressure, and maintain long-term readiness across the watchfloor, on the flight deck, or in the field






# Peer-to-Peer Support

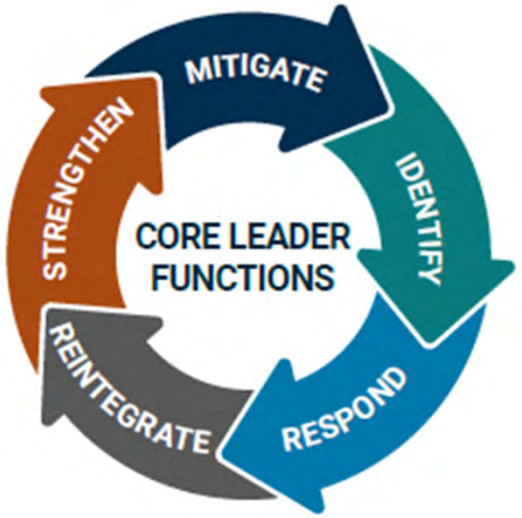
- Peer-to-peer support is the daily frontline of resilience. It's Sailors looking out for each other, recognizing when something feels off, and having the skill, and courage to engage. This isn't therapy. It's connection. It's one of the most effective ways to reduce stress before it escalates



| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **O**<br>**OBSERVE** | Actively observe behaviors—look for patterns | *"I've noticed that you have been looking really tired this week."* |
| **S**<br>**STATE OBSER-VATIONS** | Address behaviors only, just the facts without interpretations or judgements | *"This is the third time I've caught you falling asleep on watch."* |
| **C**<br>**CLARIFY ROLE** | Stating why you are concerned about the behavior validates why you are addressing the issue. | *"If Chief catches you sleeping on watch, you could end up at Captain's Mast."* |
| **A**<br>**ASK WHY** | Seek clarification; try to understand the other person's perception of the behavior. | *"I did not realize you have a two sick children at home."* |
| **R**<br>**RESPOND** | Clarify concern if indicated. Discuss desired behaviors. State options in behavioral term. | *"Let's talk with Chief, he may recommend special liberty for you."* |

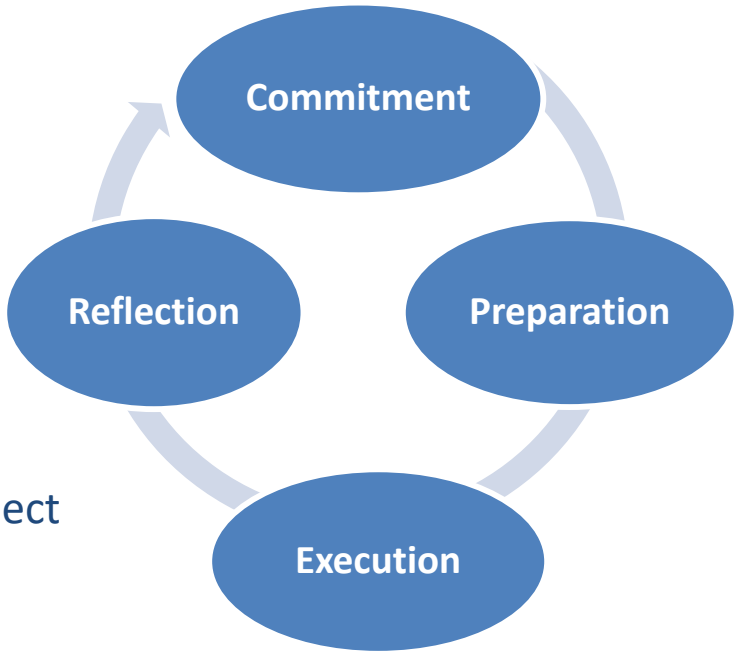
# Core Leader Functions

- Core Leader Functions consist of five areas that leaders use to assess, plan, and implement strategies for Sailors to be successful
  - ***Strengthen*** against stress reactions, injuries and illnesses
  - ***Mitigate*** the force and intensity of stressors experienced whenever possible
  - ***Identify*** the stress zones and stressors affecting individuals
  - ***Treat*** by taking actions to promote healing and hasten recovery
  - ***Reintegrate*** member with unit if possible



# EDO Warrior Mindset

- What is your mindset at the job?
- Have you thought about would happen if war starts next week?
- Have you practiced?
- Does your team know?
- Warrior mindset for EDOs
  - Commitment
    - Condition of ship underway
  - Preparation
    - Walk through the scenario mentally
    - Understand the errors when there is time to reflect
  - Execution
    - Test your team's commitment and preparation
  - Reflection
    - Focus on the bad execution ***and*** the positive



# Summary

- What is the definition of Warrior Toughness?

- What are the 4 parts of the Warrior Mindset?

# Recruit Warrior Toughness Curriculum

## Daily
(RDCs)



**Goal-Setting**



**Recalibrate**



**Mindfulness**

## Weekly
(Ship's Officers and Chaplains)

1. Introduction to Toughness
2. Toughness and Chaplaincy
3. OSC & Mindfulness
4. Toughness in Action
5. Toughness & Integrity
6. Toughness & Initiative
7. Toughness & Accountability
8. Suicide & Toughness
9. Ethical Toughness
10. End of Term Reflection

## Just-in-Time
(Instructors)

**Visualization**
***Water Survival***



**Self-Talk**
***Freedom Hall***



**Energy Mgmt**
***Seamanship***

